

ANI

THE CENTREPIECE
PM Modi in Gaya next to (left) Bihar CM Nitish Kumar and deputy CM Samrat Chaudhary, Aug. 22

▶ BIHAR

FRONTMAN AND THE FIRST-TIME VOTER

The BJP is pushing its younger leaders to court the youth, even as Modi speaks directly to aspirational youngsters and women, while the RSS quietly does the groundwork

Guru Prakash Paswan (37)—none has yet been groomed into a statewide face. Deputy CM Samrat Chaudhary, formerly with the RJD and JD(U), is still seen as an outsider by the Sangh parivar's core. The other deputy CM, Vijay Sinha, lacks organisational heft. This vacuum has forced the BJP to lean heavily on NDA partner Chirag to connect with first-time voters, especially in urban and semi-urban belts. And there's a school of thought in the BJP which holds that younger candidates may be fielded in the polls to draw youth voters to its side. Meanwhile, the party is banking on one constant: Modi.

MODI, THE CENTRAL PILLAR

No wonder, the PM is the centrepiece of the BJP's multi-layered campaign in Bihar, backed by the RSS's formidable machinery. For the Sangh parivar, the 2025 election is more than a contest for power; it is an ideological laboratory. The experiment is a fusion of Hindutva and social justice, nationalism and welfare, local caste coalitions and Modi's personal appeal. For this calibrated, reformist exercise, Bihar has been carved into five zones, each run by a state general secretary (organisation) drafted from elsewhere. Pracharaks and BJP state leaders provide the organisational muscle. The effort is monitored closely by sah-sarkaryavahs Alok Kumar and Arun Kumar, and overseen by senior zonal general secretaries Ajay Jamwal and Nagendra Kumar, both pracharaks on loan to the BJP.

Takeaways

- **Modi's appeal to women is crucial, given high turnouts**
- **BJP promotes younger faces to resonate with young voters**

Modi, an OBC himself, has promised a caste census and delivered social sector schemes, casting the BJP as a party for "all Hindus". In order to promote this *samrasta* (Hindu unity across castes), the Sangh has expanded *shakhas* in Magadh, Mithila and Seemanchal regions over the past year and dispatched pracharaks to caste-sensitive belts. The long-delayed caste census is being framed as "data for dignity", appealing to backward communities while reassuring elite caste supporters. *Shakhas* host inter-caste feasts, highlight OBC and Dalit Hindu icons, and promote rituals that cut across caste boundaries, while BJP leaders project Modi as a personal guarantee—the man behind every Ujjwala cylinder, PM Awas roof or Ayushman Bharat card. Recently, implementation of social sector schemes in the state was reviewed by home minister Amit Shah.

In a clear departure from the old Hindutva model of confrontational assertion, the BJP plans to ease itself into Bihar's political ethos. ■